

**NAMAN "MORTAL"
MATHUR**
Co-Founder,
S8UL Esports



LEVEL UP INDIA

MORTAL'S PLAYBOOK FOR INDIAN ESPORTS

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From packed arenas to packed livestream chats, Indian audiences have embraced gaming not as a fringe hobby but as a cultural force to reckon with. At the forefront of this transformation is S8UL Esports co-founder Naman "Mortal" Mathur, a trailblazer who helped legitimize competitive gaming in India and then went a step further – he helped institutionalize it.

In this exclusive interview, Mortal shares his candid thoughts on how the Indian gaming ecosystem has evolved since his early days, and what it takes to succeed in this rapidly shifting landscape.

How has Indian gaming changed, and what excites you about its future?

Naman: When I began my journey, gaming in India was largely misunderstood and often dismissed. While the passion was undeniable, the ecosystem lacked structure. Competitive opportunities were scarce, career pathways were unclear, and there was little in the way of institutional or commercial support for players and creators to build something enduring.

That landscape has transformed profoundly. Gaming today sits firmly within mainstream culture. Esports

has developed genuine competitive depth, and content creation has emerged as a credible and respected profession. What excites me most about 2026 and 2027 is that Indian gaming is transitioning from momentum-driven growth to ecosystem maturity. With esports recognised as a medal sport at the Asian Games and Indian athletes competing on that stage, societal and parental acceptance has accelerated significantly. S8UL's historic selection as a Club Partner at the Esports World Cup further underscored India's arrival on the global stage, opening pathways for more Indian teams and athletes to compete internationally, including at the upcoming Esports World Cup and the inaugural Esports Nations Cup.

Today's young Indian gamers are not driven solely by the ambition to play. They aspire to build organisations, businesses, and globally relevant IPs rooted in gaming.

As someone who began as an esports player, what's your secret for success in the Indian gaming industry?

Naman: A 360-degree approach is essential in India. Esports alone is not enough, and content alone is not sustainable unless it is supported by

strong infrastructure. By combining competitive teams, talent management, content production, and consumer products like merchandising, you create multiple revenue streams and stronger brand equity.

This approach also allows creators and players to think long term. They are not dependent only on prize money or platform algorithms. At S8UL, the idea has always been to build an ecosystem, not just an organisation, where talent can grow across different career stages.

What advice do you give to aspiring pro players or content creators in 2026?

Naman: There are far more opportunities today than when we started, but also far more competition. My advice is simple. Focus on fundamentals. If you want to be a pro player, treat it like a sport. Discipline, practice, fitness, and mindset all matter. If you want to be a creator, consistency and originality matter more than chasing trends.

Also, do not rush success. Learn the business side early, be patient with growth, and surround yourself with people who challenge you. Gaming careers are no longer short-term gambles. They can be long, meaningful journeys. 